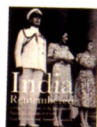


EYEWITNESS TO HISTORY

The daughter of Lord Mountbatten writes about her personal insights into the momentous events leading to Independence



INDIA REMEMBERED
by PAMELA MOUNTBATTEN
Roli/Pavilion
Price: Rs 1,495
Pages: 234

■ By Dilip Bobb

Much like batsmen and stand-up comics, publishers need an immaculate sense of timing. *India Remembered* is an inside account of the events leading up to Indian Independence released on its 60th anniversary. It is authored by a Mountbatten, the family that played such a pivotal role in the attainment of Independence and the paroxysms of Partition. Pamela Mountbatten, daughter of Lord Mountbatten, the last Viceroy of India, was 17 when she arrived in India in 1947 with her parents, who immediately plunged into hectic negotiations with Indian leaders in the desperate race to meet the deadline of August 15. She spent 15 months in what is now Rashtrapati Bhawan with a front row seat to history-in-the-making. This book is culled from the diaries she kept as well as those of her parents. There is also a foreword by India Hicks, Pamela's daughter, who adds her own experience of the country she was named after.

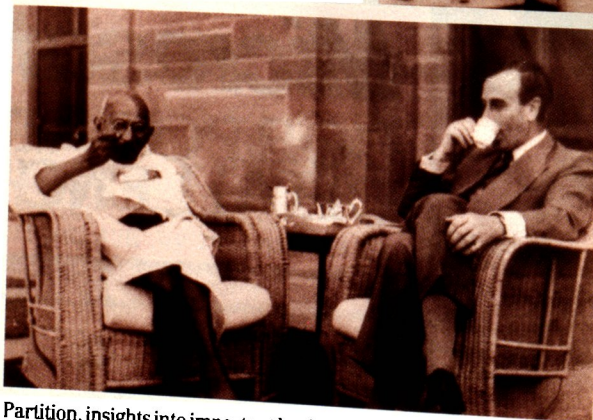
This is a personalised memoir, partly in diary form, but written by someone who had privileged and exclusive insights into one of the most significant events in modern history. Pamela describes how her father, knowing the special relationship between his wife and Nehru, often used Edwina to speak to him on tricky issues, like the Kashmir problem, when he told her: "Do try to get Jawaharlal to see that this is terribly important..."

The bond between Nehru and Edwina was the most talked about aspect of the Mountbattens' stay in India and Pamela confirms that the immedi-

ate attraction between the two "blossomed into love" and that her mother had already had other lovers, something that Mountbatten reluctantly accepted, specially in the case of Nehru. She quotes from a letter Mountbatten had written: "They (Nehru and Edwina) really dote on each other in the nicest way." She also quotes from a letter Nehru wrote to Edwina in which he says: "Suddenly, I realised (and perhaps you did also) that... some uncontrollable force... drew us to one another.... I was overwhelmed and at the same time exhilarated by this new discovery.... We could look into each other's eyes without fear or embarrassment." Pamela, however, says that the relationship remained platonic.

While much of the book covers the overpowering introduction to India, there is considerable detail about the negotiations over Independence and

A SPECIAL BOND: (Clockwise from right) The Viceroy and Edwina; the family with Nehru; Gandhi comes for tea



Partition, insights into important leaders like Jinnah ("an icy man"), Vallabhbhai Patel ("pragmatic and tough") and the drafting of the Mountbatten Plan for the transfer of power.

There is a delightful story about Independence eve when Nehru presented Mountbatten with an envelope

containing the names of his cabinet ministers. Mountbatten opened it and found it blank. In the rush of events, Nehru's staff had inserted the wrong paper. It was an incredible time and the Mountbattens led incredible lives. In India's 60th year of freedom, it is a fitting anniversary gift.